

Real-World NPCs: A Global Roster of Threats

In *Zero Sum*, the puppeteers are global. The horror of these figures is their utter detachment from the human cost of their actions.

The Tech Titans (US / Global)

- **Elias Vance (The Erratic Visionary):** An aerospace engineer and defense contractor. Owner of the micro-blogging platform "Echo" and low-orbit surveillance satellites. He is unpredictable, using his platform to manipulate global markets and incite political violence on a whim, treating the world like a simulation he owns.
- **Arthur Zuck (The Data Baron):** His "Aether" VR headsets and social platforms are the ultimate biometric panopticon. He views human emotion strictly as data to be harvested and sold to intelligence agencies.

The Global Autocrats & Oligarchs

- **Viktor Petrov (The Siloviki Mastermind):** A composite of Eastern European oligarchs. He doesn't just run an energy conglomerate; he runs a global mafia. He utilizes PMC "Valkyrie Group" for plausible deniability, assassinating dissidents across Europe with exotic nerve agents. The horror is his absolute impunity.
- **Chairman Wei (The Panopticon Architect):** A fictionalized composite of global surveillance architects. Wei oversees an algorithmic social credit system. He is terrifying because he isn't cruel; he genuinely believes that mathematically calculated social control is the only way to save humanity from itself.

The Dark Money & Cartel Lords

- **"El Fantasma" (The Cyber-Cartel Boss):** He doesn't live in a jungle camp; he lives in a luxury penthouse in Dubai. He uses big data analytics to optimize cocaine shipping routes and employs mercenary hackers to dox and assassinate judges.
- **Simon Black (The Algorithmic Launderer):** Once a wunderkind of a decentralized dark-pool exchange, now in federal custody. He laundered money for state-sponsored hackers and cartels. The horror is that the cartels want their billions back, and Simon will sell out anyone—including the players—to survive.

The Intelligence & PMC Directors

- **Director Yossi (The Spyware Merchant):** Based on the founders of NSO Group/Black Cube. Operates out of Tel Aviv. He sells zero-click exploits to autocrats. He defends his actions by claiming he only sells "software," fully washing his hands of the journalists and activists who are subsequently tortured and murdered by his clients.
- **Commander "Vulture" Vance (The Blood-Mine Overseer):** A South African ex-mercenary running security for a massive cobalt mine in the DRC. He commands a private army with attack helicopters. He is paid by Western tech companies to ensure the supply chain never stops, regardless of how many child laborers die in the mud. He represents the brutal physical violence required to maintain the digital world.